





Trotter packs
The infantry knapsack or "Trotter pack" (*right*) was a deeply resented burden. One soldier complained, "I am convinced that many of our infantry sank and died under the weight of their knapsacks". It was worn even into battle (*far right*), seen here on the Light Companies of the First Guards as they repel fierce French attacks at Hougoumont in 1815.

> "THE MEN ARE VERY PROUD OF [OFFICERS] WHO ARE BRAVE IN THE FIELD, AND KIND AND CONSIDERATE TO THE SOLDIERS UNDER THEM ... I KNOW FROM EXPERIENCE THAT IN OUR ARMY THE MEN LIKED BEST TO BE OFFICERED BY GENTLEMEN."
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> **RIFLEMAN HARRIS**, *RECOLLECTIONS*, 1808

commissioned rank, for some £500. As vacancies occurred above him in his regiment, he could then buy further promotion. Free commissions, filled by strict seniority, cropped up from time to time, offering a slow path of advancement to officers without money. Either outstanding feats of valour or influential friends in the right places occasionally allowed a man to make more rapid progress up the promotion ladder without payment. Promotion from the ranks was not common, but it did occur. About one in 20 officers were former non-commissioned officers.

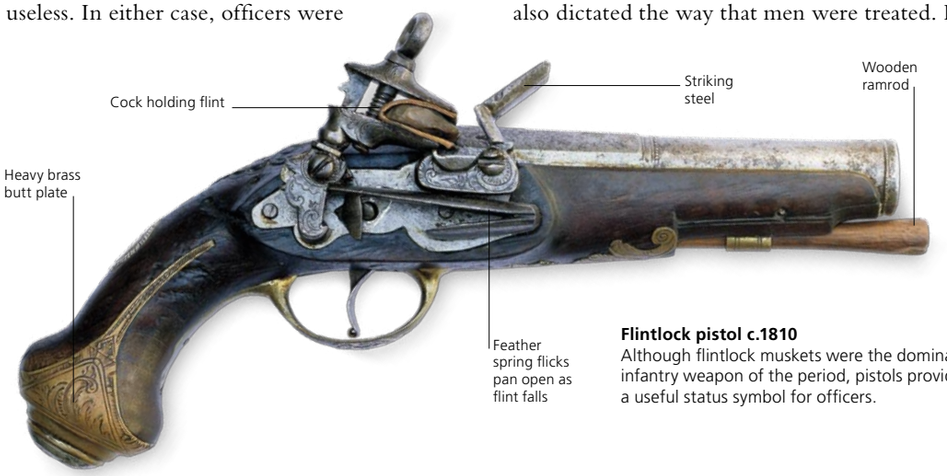
Officers could generally be relied upon to show courage in combat and, as experience of warfare accumulated in the long struggle against the French, increasing numbers of them became competent at leading their men. As in most armies, some of the officers were respected and admired by the soldiers underneath them and others were despised as ignorant and useless. In either case, officers were critically dependent on the performance of their sergeants and sergeant-majors, who were often the most experienced and professional members of a company. The sergeant-major would usually have started his career as an ordinary soldier and would certainly have been promoted on merit. His military ability had to be wedded to literacy and clerical skills, for he bore a heavy burden of paperwork in his administrative duties.

DRILL AND DISCIPLINE

Strict drill and draconian punishments were still seen as the keys to infantry performance in the British army of the Napoleonic Wars, as they had been throughout the 18th century. The use of the inaccurate flintlock musket, Brown Bess, as the main infantry weapon made disciplined volley fire essential – there was no place for individual initiative on the part of the ordinary soldier. But the assumptions of a decidedly unequal society also dictated the way that men were treated. It was taken for granted that, in the absence of corporal punishment, soldiers drawn from the common people would swiftly degenerate into a disorganized and cowardly rabble. Flogging was a commonplace response to any resistance to authority or general disorder such as drunkenness – to which soldiers were certainly prone. The aim of the system was to create infantrymen who were unquestioningly obedient to commands, who when it came to battle would manoeuvre coherently and operate their flintlock muskets with minimum harm to their comrades and themselves, and maximum harm to the enemy.

By the 1800s, however, the old ways of the army had important critics, and reforms were under way. In the light infantry ("light bobs") and the rifle regiments – which proved a valuable ancillary to the line infantry in the Peninsular War – individual initiative was not totally discouraged and a tentative effort was made to lead men more on the principle of mutual respect than of fear of punishment.

For most soldiers, in any case, there were more complex reasons to commit to a creditable performance, including the usual peer pressure and loyalty to friends and comrades found in all fighting formations. Soldiers identified strongly with their regiment and its traditions – men often fought to the death to defend the symbolically vital regimental colours. Loyalty to king and country was also present as a motivating force. Yet the Irish, serving in their own regiments or as individual soldiers in English regiments, on the whole proved outstandingly loyal and reliable,



Flintlock pistol c.1810
Although flintlock muskets were the dominant infantry weapon of the period, pistols provided a useful status symbol for officers.